



# GFG Events: Navigating Academic Freedom & AI Guidance

Navigating Generative AI Integration Through Cognitive Load Theory in Higher Education

12 August 2026

# The Governance Paradox

Balancing Systemic Policy Alignment with Academic Freedom in the Generative  
AI Era

# Policy vs. Autonomy

## Institutional Role

### Macro-Level Governance & Infrastructure

Establishes baseline policies on data privacy, ethics, accessibility, copyright protection, and equal technological access for all students.

Defines safe harbor principles without dictating specific classroom teaching strategies.

## Faculty Autonomy

### Micro-Level Pedagogical Execution

Exercises academic freedom to determine how AI tools align with course learning outcomes and discipline-specific epistemology.

Designs authentic assessments and specifies task-by-task expectations on course syllabi.

# The Risk of Policy Vagueness

## Offloading Governance to Students

When institutional policies are ambiguous or absent, the burden of interpreting compliance falls directly on students.

Conflicting course-level rules create paralysis, fear of accidental honor code violations, and massive extraneous mental overhead across different subjects.



# Cognitive Load Theory Framework

Translating Policy Expectations into Student Cognitive Clarity

# Three Dimensions of Load

$$\text{Load}_{\text{Total}} = \text{Load}_{\text{Intrinsic}} + \text{Load}_{\text{Extrinsic}} + \text{Load}_{\text{Germane}}$$



## Intrinsic Load

### Essential Complexity

The inherent difficulty of core subject matter. Protect this from arbitrary AI automation so core skill schemas can form.



## Extrinsic Load

### Instructional Friction

Mental energy wasted on unclear instructions or syntax struggles. Eliminate this by leveraging AI to streamline routine friction.



## Germane Load

### Deep Processing

The productive mental effort that builds long-term understanding. Maximize this by using AI as a Socratic thought partner.

# Reducing Extrinsic Load

68%

Student Policy Anxiety

## Eliminating Unnecessary Friction

Unclear or inconsistent guidelines across courses consume critical working memory capacity, leaving less bandwidth for deep processing.

When faculty explicitly map tool permissibility per assignment stage on the syllabus, extraneous confusion drops and students can focus entirely on learning.

# Strategic AI Load Allocation



*Optimal instructional design uses AI heavily to eliminate extrinsic barriers and stimulate germane reflection, while restricting AI when building core intrinsic schemas.*



# Cognitive Load Matrix

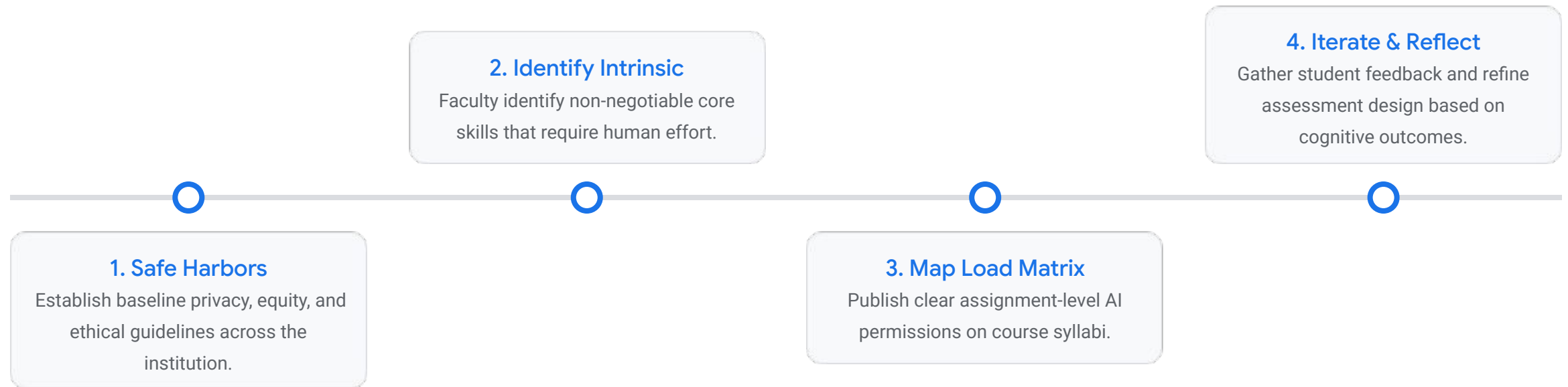
| Assignment Stage      | AI Policy Status | Target Load Type       | Pedagogical Rationale                                                               |
|-----------------------|------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Brainstorming      | Allowed          | Reduce Extrinsic Load  | Overcomes initial blank-page paralysis and encourages exploration.                  |
| 2. Primary Analysis   | Prohibited       | Protect Intrinsic Load | Requires direct student engagement with raw sources to construct core knowledge.    |
| 3. Thesis & Synthesis | Collaborative    | Maximize Germane Load  | AI acts as a Socratic peer to challenge assumptions and generate counter-arguments. |
| 4. Proofreading       | Allowed          | Reduce Extrinsic Load  | Frees up cognitive bandwidth to focus on argument structure and evidence quality.   |

# AI as Socratic Thought Partner

- **Shift from Detection to Scaffolding:** Move institutional focus from policing outputs toward process-oriented learning.
- **Active Critique:** Require students to evaluate, verify, and counter-argue AI outputs rather than accepting them passively.
- **Metacognitive Reflection:** Include reflection prompts asking students to articulate how AI shaped their thinking.
- **Epistemic Autonomy:** Preserves faculty freedom while giving students actionable clarity.



# Implementation Roadmap



# Questions & Discussion

Empowering Academic Freedom Through Clear Instructional Boundaries

GFG Events Series

# How to Engage Further

Higher Ed Active Learning Challenge



[Smart Grading: Designing Objective Rubrics with Gemini](#)



[Shifting the Grade: Process-Based Grading & Academic Integrity](#)



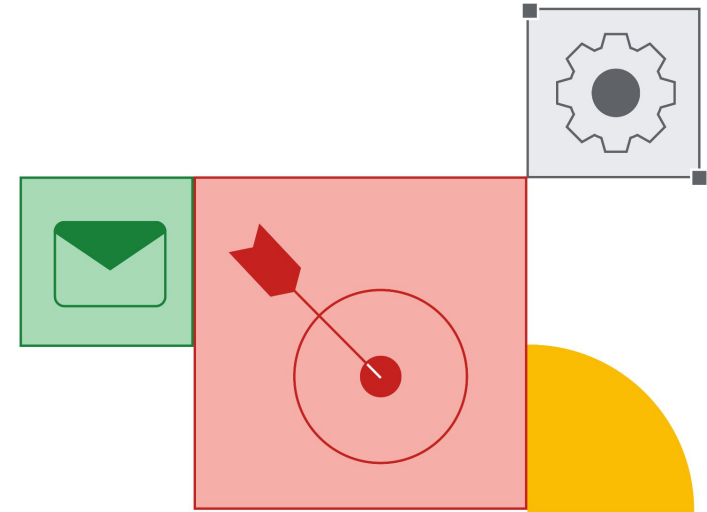
[Career-Ready Curriculum: Mapping Industry Competencies](#)



[Decoding Academic Research: Making Journals Accessible](#)



[Immersive Role-Plays: Simulating Real-World Practice](#)



# Join our Sept. Assignment Redesign Cohort

A 1-month Asynchronous Experience for Higher Education Faculty

## What You Will Accomplish:

**01** Redesign a Core Course Assessment

**02** Design Away from Unintentional Offloading

**03** Shift from Output Policing to Process Learning

**04** Engage in a Global Faculty Network

### September 2026 Registration

#### Format & Hub

4-Week Asynchronous Group Hub

#### Start Date

September 2026

#### Target Audience

Instructional Faculty, Deans, Department Chairs, and Instructional Designers

Ready to join the cohort?

[Link in Chat](#)

# Links & References

## THE GOVERNANCE PARADOX (SLIDE 2)

**AAC&U & Elon University (2026)**

National survey: 95% of faculty fear student overreliance on AI... [Link](#)

**Tyton Partners & D2L (2026)**

Time for class 2026: The AI tipping point. [Link](#)

## POLICY VS. AUTONOMY (SLIDE 3)

**Chan (2023)**

A comprehensive AI policy education framework... [Link](#)

## POLICY VAGUENESS (SLIDE 4)

**HEPI (2025) & Chan & Hu (2023)**

Student GenAI Survey 2025 / Students' voices. [HEPI](#) | [Chan](#)

## COGNITIVE LOAD THEORY (SLIDES 5-7)

**Sweller (1988)**

Cognitive load during problem solving. [Link](#)

**Sweller, van Merriënboer, & Paas (1998)**

Cognitive architecture & instructional design. [Link](#)

**Risko & Gilbert (2016)**

Cognitive offloading mechanisms. [Link](#)

## LOAD ALLOCATION & MATRIX (SLIDES 8-9)

**Lodge et al. (2023)**

Learning in the age of generative AI. [Link](#)

**Bearman & Ajjawi (2023)**

Learning to think with generative AI. [Link](#)

## ROADMAPS & PARTNERS (SLIDES 10-11)

**Mollick & Mollick (2023)**

Assigning AI: Seven approaches. [Link](#)

**UNESCO (2023)**

Guidance for generative AI in education. [Link](#)

## COMMUNITY & REGISTRATION

**Active Learning Challenge (Slide 14)**

Join resource sharing. [Community Hub](#)

**Assignment Redesign Cohort (Slide 15)**

September GFG Cohort registration. [Register Here](#)